

Trust Accounting + Owner Reporting + Maintenance Workflow Fix for 120-Door Mixed Portfolio

Executive summary — The firm self-manages 120 doors (80 SFR + 40 units across five 8-plexes in DFW) with 4 people. Current stack is Buildium (3 years) + QuickBooks Online + spreadsheets for owner statements. Maintenance is phone/text-driven with photos lost in text threads. Month-end owner close takes 2 full days. AppFolio was tried 4 years ago at 70 doors but was too expensive per unit. The decision is whether to stay on Buildium despite price increase or switch to a PMS with true trust accounting, reliable QBO sync, owner portal with per-property P&L, and full maintenance work order lifecycle with photos/receipts/billing tied to the WO, plus mobile field app, under \$250/month all-in, with 2-year history migration and hands-on onboarding, avoiding Oct-Dec go-live.

The decision

Switch from Buildium + QBO + spreadsheets to a PMS that delivers true trust accounting, reliable QBO sync, owner self-serve P&L; portal, and full maintenance WO lifecycle with photos and vendor billing, or stay on Buildium if no suitable option meets budget, migration, and blackout constraints.

Decision maker

Owner-Operator, self-managing 120 doors, DFW — 80 SFR + 40 units in five 8-plexes, team of 1 owner + 2 office + 1 field tech.

Situation

Portfolio: 120 doors mixed SFR and small multifamily, DFW market. Current tools: Buildium for 3 years as core PMS, QuickBooks Online for corporate books, spreadsheets for owner statements because Buildium statements don't satisfy owners. No vendor portal — coordinator logs tenant call/text in Buildium then calls vendor by phone. Photos and receipts from turns and maintenance live in text threads, not tied to work orders. Volume: ~30 maintenance WOs per week, ~40 leases per year, ~15 owner reports per month. Turn season in summer is peak pain. Team: owner does owner communication and final accounting, 1 office staff does accounting/reconciliation, 1 office staff does leasing/maintenance coordination, 1 field tech does turn checks and photos but no app. Double entry between Buildium and QBO is recurring issue. Owner statements require 2 days at month-end. Buildium price increase is trigger but not sole driver.

Desired outcome

Month-end close in 4 hours not 2 days. Owners self-serve per-property P&L, statements, and documents via portal and stop texting owner for reports. Every work order has photos and receipt attached, billed to correct property, vendor assigned and paid, visible to tenant and owner. No double entry between PMS and QBO — sync actually works. Field tech uses mobile app to capture photos on site tied to WO. Won't switch just to save \$30 if accounting is worse — reliability over small cost saving.

Prior experience

- AppFolio for 8 months four years ago at 70 doors — too expensive per unit and forced payment processing fees, left for cost reasons
- Excel + QBO only before Buildium — chaos for trust accounting, no audit trail, abandoned
- Buildium 3 years — works for basic but owner reporting requires spreadsheets, QBO sync breaks causing double entry, no vendor portal, price increase now

Priorities

- True trust accounting with reconciled security deposits and owner balances — lawsuit risk if wrong
- Reliable QuickBooks Online sync without double entry
- Owner portal with per-property P&L, statements, and document self-serve
- Maintenance lifecycle: tenant request → coordinator triage → vendor assignment → photo capture → receipt/billing → tenant/owner visibility
- Mobile app for field tech to capture photos tied to WO
- Per-property accounting and vendor bill tied to WO not lost in texts

Constraints

- Budget under \$250/month all-in — per unit pricing must fit 120 doors
- Must migrate 2 years history: leases, ledgers, security deposits, open WOs, owner balances
- Hands-on onboarding help required, not just videos
- Blackout: no go-live Oct-Dec due to renewal season risk for lease mistakes
- Team of 4, cannot afford dedicated migration resource, must keep operations running during migration

Options considered

- Do nothing / Keep Buildium + QBO + spreadsheets despite price increase and 2-day close
- Switch to RentManager or DoorLoop or Buildium competitor with strong trust accounting + QBO sync + owner portal + maintenance WO lifecycle
- Switch to AppFolio Property Manager Plus again if pricing now works at 120 doors with negotiated processing
- Stay on Buildium but add external owner reporting tool and maintenance add-on like VendorPM or Property Meld to patch gaps

Tradeoffs

- Staying on Buildium avoids migration risk for deposits/owner balances but continues 2-day close and double entry and price increase
- Switching PMS fixes trust accounting and owner portal but migration of security deposits and owner balances carries lawsuit-level risk if mis-mapped
- Adding add-ons to Buildium is lower migration risk but creates new integration points where QBO sync could still break and adds \$ to stay under \$250/mo
- AppFolio again gives strong accounting but reintroduces per-unit cost and forced payment processing that caused churn at 70 doors, now at 120 doors cost pressure higher
- Full WO lifecycle with photos helps turn season but requires vendor adoption of portal — vendors ignoring portal makes maintenance worse and tenant churn risk

Risks and concerns

- Data migration messing up security deposits and owner balances — lawsuit territory per owner statement
- Double entry creeping back if QBO sync breaks after switch — same problem as today
- Vendors ignoring new portal and continuing phone/text, making maintenance coordination worse
- Downtime or lease errors if go-live hits Oct-Dec renewal season — explicit blackout
- Price under \$250/mo may exclude platforms with true trust accounting and hands-on onboarding

Unknowns

- Which candidate PMS actually delivers reliable QBO sync without double entry for 120-door mixed portfolio?
- Exact migration mapping for security deposits, prepaid rent, and owner reserves from Buildium to new PMS?
- Vendor adoption rate for portal vs phone — will existing vendors use it or require replacement?
- Hands-on onboarding cost and whether it is included in <\$250/mo or extra?
- Owner portal self-serve P&L; format — does it satisfy current owners who receive spreadsheet statements today?

Decision criteria

- True trust accounting with audit trail for deposits and owner balances
- Reliable QBO sync without double entry — must be proven not marketed
- Owner portal with per-property P&L; and document self-serve
- Maintenance WO lifecycle with photos, receipt, vendor assignment, billing tied to WO, tenant/owner visibility
- Mobile field app for turn checks and photo capture
- Total cost under \$250/month all-in at 120 doors including payments if forced
- 2-year history migration included with hands-on onboarding, and ability to avoid Oct-Dec go-live

Next steps

1. Request Buildium full export (tenants, leases, chart of accounts, deposit ledger, owner balances, open WOs, attachments) to assess migration complexity
2. Shortlist 3 PMS: one trust-accounting-first (RentManager, DoorLoop), one mid-market with strong mobile (Buildium alternative), and re-quote AppFolio at 120 doors with processing pass-through
3. Demo script: create WO from tenant text, assign vendor, field tech adds photos via mobile, attach receipt, bill to property, owner sees per-property P&L; QBO sync shows no duplicate
4. Ask each vendor: security deposit migration mapping, QBO sync failure rate, owner portal P&L; sample, vendor portal adoption data, onboarding included vs extra, blackout go-live support
5. Run parallel month for September with one owner portfolio to validate 4-hour close before full cutover avoiding Oct-Dec

Recommendation

Do not switch just for \$30 savings. Proceed only if a candidate proves true trust accounting, QBO sync without double entry, and maintenance lifecycle with photos/billing in a parallel September close for one owner group, with 2-year deposit/owner balance migration validated and hands-on onboarding included under \$250/mo, avoiding Oct-Dec go-live. If no candidate passes the parallel close demo, stay on Buildium and patch with dedicated maintenance add-on while re-negotiating Buildium pricing.

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